

My rebirth

My wife always used to ask me “What will you do after me?” as she was fully aware that I was fully dependent on her in all aspects of my life. I would smile and say “Don’t worry, I will go before you”. This had almost come true, when I was on the brink of death during 2017.

During early months of 2017, my wife’s illness was a bit stable as one of the medicine under trial and being imported from U.K had worked well for few months and I was able to concentrate more on my professional life. FY 2016-17 was the first year of IND- AS transition, this along with some other important assignments were keeping me busy, and for that reason I had many foreign travels during that period until August, 2017. But her illness again resurfaced from August 2017, and this time it had spread to her brain (covered in my last writing also) and chest. We went to Bangalore to address and treat the tumor in her brain with an aggressive new technology called the cyber knife, which seemed to have made an impact. But, the illness was gradually growing in her chest as well. During this period, I had also developed some cough and cold, which I was ignoring constantly as my wife’s illness was always my sole concern.

In the last week of October 2017, on Saturday, we got all required tests done for my wife and were waiting for the reports, as it was almost certain that illness had recurred and will require treatment again. But, the coming Tuesday night around 3.30 AM, I felt acute breathlessness. I was taken to a nearby hospital and was admitted to the emergency. I was given oxygen and some nebulizer etc. With that I felt slightly comfortable. But on the advice of attending doctors, I was admitted to the ICU. Next morning when the specialist doctor visited, he found that my lungs was highly infected (almost 95% of lungs had patches of white as shown on the X-Ray). They debated with their team, whether I should be put on ventilator support and then they decided to go for that. The sheer mention of ventilator had frightened us and led to the feeling that now it is end of the road for my life. However, some resident doctors consoled us that this is not the case and many have come out of the same.

A board of doctors comprising of all sorts of specialists (pulmonologists, hematologists, critical care etc.) was formed and all sorts of tests were carried out. I was on 100% ventilator support for 10 days and was mostly kept on sedatives along with high dose of antibiotics. During this period doctors had not given any hopes of my survival. It was concluded that I had severe infection but

the source could not be found. Possible reasons were either my foreign visits or hospital borne infections due to frequent visits for my wife. Whenever I had some sense, I could feel the intolerable pain of large tubes in my throat. After 14 days, ventilators were finally removed and I was shifted to the non-ICU room finally released from hospital after 19 days.

This period of 19 days had given me so many invaluable experiences of life which are difficult to mention in entirety but I will try to do so.

- I was told by my family members that, they were called twice to say that possibly I am no more, but I proved them wrong and came back.
- During this time, I had visualized the virtual death and feeling of the same.
- During this time, while I accepted that nothing is in my hands , what I can only do is to make my will power stronger and fight till the last, leaving the rest on God.
- This period had made me aware of the actual worth of your family, friends, work place and all your well wishers which is beyond description.
- I will try to mention some of this in the paragraphs below which may not be exclusive.

First of all, I would like to mention about the medical fraternity, especially junior doctors and attending sisters and brothers. They had given tremendous support to me to remain stronger and keep the hopes alive. Once I was feeling terribly low with all sorts of attachments and acute sufferings. So much so , that I started shouting and insisted that let every thing be removed and I be left to die. I could not tolerate any more. But they had handled this very well, they told me that after fighting for so long with your will power, we cannot let you sink like that. They did whatever was in their hands and made me somewhat comfortable. I still remember a sister, who was on my duty came to me and said, “Yesterday I had taken a leave just to go to the church and pray for you”. She also said, “I could see how you and your family are fighting, and I thought it to be proper on my part to do a bit of this”. I got a lot of strength with their acts which made me think that this world is full of such beautiful souls and it is a wonderful place to live.

My wife, despite her critical illness, stood firmly with me. She was allowed to meet me daily for 2 mins in ICU, she would always come and tell me “You cannot go before me, you will have to come back “. She used to sit in the hospital waiting room, up until I was out of the ICU despite her deteriorating health (her lungs

was deeply affected by cancer by then) and would interact with doctors as and when required. Her condition was so bad that she could not come once I was shifted to the regular room. Even when in the ICU, I was concerned for her health and contacted her oncologist doctor and tried to convince him to start her treatment soon. She was admitted to hospital the very next day, I was released. This time, condition was much worse and the doctor indicated to me, that the disease had spread so much in her lungs that it was approaching the terminal stage. This was the first time in ten years, when I could not attend her at the hospital and take care of her, as I was strictly advised rest for at least 15 days after release.

My son, who was then, just 22 years of age had displayed tremendous amount of maturity and handled the situation better than any matured adult could have. Every time he would come to me, he would just convey positive news only, and say, "You are on the course to recovery". He handled all the pulls and pressure with utmost calmness. In this period, he himself had to sacrifice his ambition of his life as he was preparing for the CAT exams and was aspiring to get admission in a top management school in India. But my illness and subsequent illness of my wife (which he had to look after due to my absence), he could not mentally and physically prepare for the same. He just appeared for the exams unprepared, in between attending my wife at the hospital. He, therefore could not get the desired scores. But his sacrifice did not go in vain as he got an opportunity of doing masters abroad through one of the best B-schools in India. Which, he has now completed and is now settled with a job in Europe. Possibly, this was his destiny, and God is so kind to take care of him and gave him his due returns for the sacrifices he has made in his life. I feel proud of him when people praise him for showing utmost maturity during that period.

I will not do justice If I don't mention of the support that I received from my family (my brother, sisters, brothers in law, sisters in law and their family), my boss, my office colleagues, friends of my son and people from my professional world. After 10 days, when I regained consciousness, I was told that my entire family was sitting downstairs for the last 10 days and now that I was recovering, they were planning to go back. Many of them came from different places of India, they were not even allowed to meet me in the ICU, but they came to stand by my family in the hour of crisis and this was truly remarkable for me.

My boss, who was abroad, was so concerned, that he himself contacted the renowned doctors to attend me immediately. He instructed the office people to

attend to me at the hospital and report to him on an hourly basis. My office colleagues had also provided their whole-hearted support. My sons' friends were always around him day and night so that he does not feel alone.

Once I recovered, I came to know that there were so many prayers, yagnas, pujas offered by many of the distant relatives or acquaintances. I felt like I had the blessings of super divine power of spiritual gurus and through their blessings, I could fight this impossible battle and emerge victorious.

Now almost five years have passed of that nightmare incident, and I am absolutely fine and healthy without any signs or after-effects of that illness.

However, that incident will always remain as an un-forgetful memory and serve as a reminder to me of many things which I will try to summarize below:-

- Life is so uncertain and unpredictable, so live every moment of it to the fullest.
- Health is your greatest wealth and so take care of it in the best possible way.
- Next, your family, friends, colleagues and acquaintances are your most valuable assets, try to preserve those assets with good behavior and reciprocation.
- In this struggle, the support, sympathy and kindness of everyone is a reminder that you should not forget to do your bit whenever the situation demands the same from you. Reciprocation is a sign of humanity within you.
- These types of incidences serve as a reminder that you should not let this life go in vain and lead life with a purpose and goal.

I will close this post thanking all of you for reading through the snippets of my life so patiently.